

Growing up into Christ

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“... we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into
Christ...”

Ephesians 4:15b

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Introduction

Christians are those who have made a decision to follow Jesus Christ as Lord, or Master, in this life. As Christ's disciples of today, we have given up our own will in favor of following God's will for our days. We have been bought at the high price of Jesus' suffering and death, redeemed from sin and eternal death, and we are not our own.

What does God have for each of us in this life? It is to daily choose to be *clothed with* the Spirit of God as Jesus Christ was, enabling us to grow up *in every way* into Him who is the Head, into Jesus Christ (Ephesians 4:15b). To become mature as sons and daughters of God (2 Corinthians 6:16-18) is to attain the fullness of Christ (Ephesians 4:13), for God predestined each of us to be conformed to the image of His Son, in order that He might be the firstborn among many brothers (Romans 8:29).

To grow up into Christ is to choose to allow God's Spirit that lives in us to cause us to daily: think as Jesus (our Head) thinks, speak (out of the overflow of our heart) as Jesus speaks, act as Jesus acts. This book is my journey with you to reflect on what that looks like so we can intentionally choose just that.

This is our destiny. Glory be to God.

Availability

The Spirit of God does not force us. The Spirit allows us to choose to do what is important to us.

Jesus still seeks followers that are available.

When Jesus called His disciples, He expected them to abandon everything to follow after Him. Nothing about that call has changed.

Reflecting on Jesus' ministry, He made Himself available to all to meet their needs. Jesus met spiritual and physical needs through His preaching and demonstration of [the gospel of the kingdom](#). He also gave the Jewish scribes what they most needed: rebuke.

Growing up into every way into Christ means growing in these ways related to availability: making ourselves fully available to our Lord's will and interests and making ourselves fully available to His image bearers to meet their needs.

How available are you to give your attention to our Father's interests in this world as Christ did and still does?

How available are you now to be a doer of God's word, as Christ was and still is?

How available do you make yourself now to meet the needs of others in the ways that Jesus met and still meets needs?

When we don't make ourselves available, God's work and word are not done.

To make yourself available is the first step of obedience for disciples of Jesus Christ.

When someone asks you how you are and you reply, "Busy," what is it you have made yourself busy with? God allows us to choose to do what is important to us.

Boldness

When the Spirit of God abides in us, we will be bold like Jesus was and is bold. We will be [bold like Peter](#) after receiving the Spirit at Pentecost. We'll be [bold like Paul](#) after his conversion to the faith.

The word for boldness in the New Testament also means unreservedness in speaking openly, free and fearless confidence, all out spokenness, frankness, cheerful courage, assurance. What is it that you most love to talk about?

If God and God's interests are the most important in your life, you will be obedient to the commands in God's word to give testimony, to preach and demonstrate the gospel of the kingdom, to make disciples, and to build His family, His church. While preaching these days is almost exclusively done in private, the meaning of the word preach in the New Testament suggests that it is done openly, just as Jesus, Peter and Paul preached openly for all to hear. While we should most often approach people with the great loving heart of the Son of God, the tone and content of the preaching of Jesus, Peter and Paul depended upon the audience and what was *right* and necessary for them to hear.

The Spirit abiding in us gives us a single focus on the reality of God and His interests that eliminates division between public and private life and every compartmentalization of life. Let's rid ourselves of the *tradition of man* that makes us double-minded, breaking our lives into sacred and secular compartments, or [rooms](#), whilst putting a leash on our tongue. This tradition breaks the most important commandment of scripture. If God is to be anything to us at all, Jesus must truly be made Lord over all and the Spirit of God must be invited into our entire life. This is what it means for you to abide in Him and Him in you.

Let us not be ashamed to speak freely of our Lord and of God's truth. The gospel is the power of God for salvation for all who come to believe it. How will they have a chance to believe it and be saved if they do not hear? It is our responsibility to be light to the world the entire time we are in it.

Let us also approach our God with boldness, knowing His will is good, knowing what is ours for the taking from Christ's finished work, and obedient to channel His goodness and life to the part of the world we've been created to bless.

Compassion

As demonstrated first in the person of Jesus Christ, God's kind of compassion is the love of God *put into action*, motivated by a hatred of evil and its effects on God's beloved image bearers.

Compassion is what moved Jesus Christ to occupy Himself and His disciples to carry out all of the good work God chose for them in the pages of scripture. Peter summarized Christ's chosen work this way:

"how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him."

Acts 10:38 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/act.10.38.ESV>

Jesus Christ's good work was motivated by a hatred of evil and its effects on people, making them harassed (thrown down and thrown around) and helpless (weakened to exhaustion, faint hearted), like sheep without a shepherd:

"And Jesus went throughout all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues and proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom and healing every disease and every affliction. When he saw the crowds, he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd."

Matthew 9:35-36 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mat.9.35-36.ESV>

God's compassion correctly sees people in the condition they are in, which is an effect of evil (a natural progression of sinful nature from the fall of man), hates it, and is bold to step out and do something, channeling the goodness of God to make it right. This is what it means to overcome evil with good.¹

Compassion is the greatest part of God's character, and it can only be born in us as partakers of His divine nature. When we abide in Him and He in us, the Spirit of God sheds His love abroad in our hearts, causing us to make ourselves available, get up, get out there, and do something — and to do what only God can do to make things right in the life of another person. We who put the love of God into action are coworkers together with God.

¹ The gospel of the kingdom includes both open proclamation of the good news in Christ and demonstration of the rule of God over every disease and affliction. Jesus Christ's demonstration of the kingdom follows from God's compassion.

Determination

God's relentless determination does not stop until it has what is intended.

God's main intent for His creation was a beloved family of sons and daughters like Him for close, eternal relationship. His intent is to bring the perfection and goodness of the kingdom of heaven to earth. God's intent is fullness of life.

For a time, God the Father had this relationship first with His first creations on earth. After some time, God the Son came to reset His kingdom on earth into motion, overcoming evil and its effects insofar as God's kingdom takes hold. Shortly thereafter, God's Holy Spirit came to enable multiplication of Christ in His faithful followers, extending God's kingdom in all of the earth. Finally, Jesus Christ will come a second time to complete God's intended work, realizing God's family and kingdom on earth forever.

Right now, God's kingdom in the world includes the lives over which He has government and rule, such that His will is being done. As God's kingdom takes hold over creation, the works and the domain of darkness lose ground. This was God's purpose in the coming of His Son Jesus Christ into the world: to destroy the works of the devil.

Jesus' ministry best modeled how God's determination is able to extend into a human filled with His Spirit, for Jesus had emptied Himself, being born in the likeness of men. Yet, this Spirit-filled man spoke the end result, believed what He spoke would come to pass, and it always did. Through the touch of His hands, this Spirit-filled man channeled the abundant life of God into all of those who needed it. On one recorded occasion (Mark 8:22-25), it took two tries, and He finished the work. Jesus taught and expected His disciples to do the same. When they stopped short of bringing the goodness of the kingdom of heaven to earth, He chastised them for it and finished the work (Matthew 17:14-20, Mark 9:14-29).

Jesus showed us what it means to hunger and thirst after righteousness, or righteous results. Now God in Christ always leads us in triumphal procession, if we will stand firm in faith until we have what God has intended.

Faith

Faith is trusting God will do what He said in His word. Ultimately, faith is trusting in God Himself.

Jesus Christ, the Word made flesh, said He came not to abolish God's word (the Law and the Prophets), but to fulfill them. It is impossible for God's word to fail.

Modeling the closest relationship with the Father via one filled with His Spirit, a direct connection, Jesus always spoke God's word and did God's word. Jesus demonstrated God's nature and character and kingdom in all that He did. Jesus' disciples had a certain perception of what the Messiah would do, but, filled with the fullness of God, He was able to do far more abundantly than what they would have thought. Filled with the fullness of God, Jesus healed every sick person, cast out every demon He came across, brought the dead to life, and called those things which were not as though they were, and they became. Jesus also taught and expected His disciples to do the same.

They were to do this by faith.

We who follow Him now are also His disciples. Jesus taught us: "Trust in God... only believe."

Let's not limit God by what we choose to believe. Let's not limit God by our traditions, making His word of no effect in our situation.

God and God's intent and God's word are good. So let's expect Him to be faithful to His word. Let's expect Him to do good in our situation rather than limit Him. There are no hindrances for Him. He is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us. Let that be our expectation of Him.

When our faith mixes within the power of God that we already received when the Holy Spirit came upon us, all things are possible.

Freedom

It is in God's nature to free those who are oppressed and afflicted by any evil. We see His nature culminated in the person of Jesus Christ, who declared His ministry would be about proclaiming good news to the poor, proclaiming liberty to the captives, recovering of sight to the blind, setting at liberty those who are oppressed, proclaiming the year of the Lord's favor. Then He did just that.

As we grow up into Christ, we are set free from any effect of evil. The Spirit of the Lord upon us, we are set free from any besetting sin, from any infirmity, from any sickness, and from anything that competes with the Lordship of Jesus Christ in our life. To be set free, we must insist that we have received what Christ has made freely available to us. We expect that the righteousness of God that we have become in Jesus Christ brings victory to every situation, making it right, just as it did with Christ. God is with us, in us, and for us.

The Spirit of the Lord upon us, we desire freedom for all others, carrying His life around with us to channel it to those we witness and minister to. We give away His life by proclaiming and demonstrating the gospel of the kingdom. Just as God set us free, He is able to set them free. We disciple them until they are free and able to set more people free. We expect the righteousness of God to bring victory to them.

Grace

Grace is the divine outflowing of the generous nature of God, channeling every good thing that it may to the world God so loves.

While our sin nature tries to keep what is good for ourselves, as if closing our hands to keep it, as we grow up into Christ, our hands open up and we learn to be generous in every way God makes possible.

Our first step as new followers of Christ is to be able to give a tithe. Then we add to it offerings. This is just the beginning of obedience.

God also has for us to give away our time and energy and attention for His interests. It all belongs to Him. His will is to make us channels of His grace.

Through us, God meets the needs of the world, both physical and spiritual. Through us, God feeds the hungry, clothes the naked, gives to the poor, welcomes strangers and marginalized persons, visits prisoners, visits the sick, heals the sick. Through us, God shows mercy to the world. Through us, God loves and serves every neighbor. Through us, God shows honor to parents and brings children unto Himself.

Through us, God channels freedom, life and blessing, beginning with the proclamation of His life and freedom-giving gospel. Through us, God brings justice and rightness to the world. Through us, God makes enemies into sons and daughters. Through us, God tends and feeds His sheep. Through our words spoken in faith, God overcomes obstacles that hinder His kingdom's expansion. Through us, God raises up the spiritually dead and the physically dead.

When you grow up into Christ, you allow the goodness of God to freely flow through you. Freely you have received, so freely give.

Humility

We all need to know this: “It’s not about you.” The only special one is Jesus Christ, exalted at the right hand of the Father, His name above every name in heaven, on earth and under the earth.

Whatever God has made you capable of doing, now and in the future, anyone could do.

Our example and the one we are to be conformed to is our Lord, Christ Jesus, whose Spirit and mind lives in our spirit:

“Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others. Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.”

Philippians 2:3-8 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/php.2.3-8.ESV>

We only obtain this kind of humility by dying to ourselves, as one who has been crucified with Christ Jesus. We have chosen to lose our old life, so our old person is dead and the body of sin destroyed with it. Having also been raised together with Christ, we are to stand fast, living as those set free, rather than submitting ourselves again to any yoke of bondage associated with the old life of sin and death.

Those who are dead do not respond to a pat on the back, nor even being stabbed in the back. This is humility. Instead, we become servants to all of mankind, *nothing* being beneath us. As obedient disciples who publicize the gospel, we expect persecution, we bless and do good to our enemies, and we pray for those who hate, persecute, speak evil of, and abuse us. In this kind of living, we can rejoice and be exceedingly glad, knowing that we are following in the steps of our Lord.

Power

Anything is possible with God because of His Almighty power. Because God was with Jesus via the Holy Spirit, everything became possible for Him.

Further, Christ taught that anything is possible for one who believes. Before His ascension, Christ instructed that His disciples would receive power when the Holy Spirit came upon them so that they could be obedient to carry out Jesus' commission to go into all of the world. Through the Spirit, Peter explained that this Holy Spirit is for all believers, even those who are far off (us).

The source of our power to be used to accomplish God's will on earth, making things as they are in heaven, is our complete identification with the ascended, enthroned Jesus Christ at the right hand of God.

While it can be difficult for us to believe at first that we carry God's power with us to use at will, when our will has been aligned with His, we must remember that it is really God working with us, confirming His message that we boldly speak in Jesus' name, bearing witness by signs, wonders and miracles. It is God working with us, stretching out His hand to heal. It is the finger of God that drives out demons when we tell them to "come out."

If we are not seeing his power, we must remember that God has given the Holy Spirit to those who obey Him (Acts 5:32) and we must be determined. God's relentless determination does not stop until it has what is intended.

Righteousness

Righteousness is to be made as we ought to be with respect to God, the sons and daughters He created put into right relationship with Him. It represents Adam and Eve before the fall and, even more so, Jesus Christ, and who we are made in Christ.

This is how we were put into right relationship with God:

“For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.”

2 Corinthians 5:21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2co.5.21.ESV>

To be in Christ means to possess the same Holy Spirit, the same divine nature attributes as God’s Son, the same victory, and the same rich inheritance. This is to be made right and acceptable.

Having the same Holy Spirit, we are put into rightful position as sons and daughters of God and empowered to boldly defeat any evil and meet any need. Having put on His divine nature, we renounce ungodliness and worldly passions, living self-controlled, upright and godly lives. Having put on His divine nature, we are ever able to walk in integrity, including correctness of thinking, feeling and acting.

Like Christ, we have been enabled to lead a lifestyle of victory on earth in every situation we encounter. As such, we are to seek after right results. Zealous for good works, we are bold to seek rightness for others we encounter. This is to hunger and thirst after righteousness. In so doing, we bring rightful glory to God.

Having been made righteous, our decree before God is “Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.” His kingdom is his government, His rule, the places where His will is done.

Growing up into Christ, we seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness. As a result of righteousness, we have access to the riches in glory in Christ Jesus to supply every need now, and in the coming ages He will show us the immeasurable riches of His grace in kindness toward us.